



TODAY, OUR FELLOW CITIZENS, OUR WAY OF LIFE, OUR VERY FREEDOM CAME UNDER ATTACK

THE 9/11 ATTACKS (2001)

IN CONTEXT

FOCUS

Rise of Islamic radicalism

BEFORE

1979 The Islamic Revolution of Iran replaces the pro-Western shah with Shia Muslim cleric Ayatollah Khomeini.

1989 As Soviet troops leave Afghanistan, Saudi millionaire Osama bin Laden forms al-Qaeda to fight a new *jihād* (struggle).

February 26, 1993 Al-Qaeda makes its ambitions clear with an audacious attack on the World Trade Center, New York.

AFTER

2004 Al-Qaeda urges Sunni Muslims to rise up against US forces in Iraq. Bombings by Islamic extremists in Madrid, Spain, kill 190 people.

February 2014 Terrorist group ISIS aims to create an Islamic caliphate that covers Iraq and Syria and spreads its influence worldwide.

On September 11, 2001, a group of Islamic extremists launched a devastating attack against the US. Two hijacked airliners crashed into the World Trade Center in New York; another hit the Pentagon, in Washington, D.C.; and a fourth plane crashed in Pennsylvania. Almost 3,000 people were killed.

“ We love death more than you love life.
al-Qaeda motto ”

The seeds of extremism

September 11 was not the first terror attack on American soil by Islamic extremists. On February 26, 1993, a bomb was detonated at the World Trade Center by men thought to have links to al-Qaeda, a militant Islamist organization. Some Muslims had been radicalized and adopted international terrorism during the struggles over Israel. In 1979, the Soviet invasion of Afghanistan led to the worldwide mobilization of Muslim militants to fight the invaders. Around that time, Osama Bin Laden formed al-Qaeda. Intelligence reports suggested that he was the mastermind behind September 11. He was killed in 2011.

The civil war in Syria since 2011 and the power vacuum left by the departure of US forces in Iraq has led to the emergence of ISIS, the so-called Islamic State of Iraq and Syria, which has taken control of several towns in the region.

The events of September 11 mark the largest terrorist attack ever on US soil. Subsequent attacks in London, Madrid, and Paris, carried out by a diffuse network of regional terrorist groups, have added a chilling dimension to the threat of Islamic terrorism. ■